

Hessel Oosterbeek

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July 2026

Current positions

Researcher, Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam, 2026-
Em. Professor, Universiteit van Amsterdam, 2026-

Other affiliations

Fellow Tinbergen Institute, 1993-
Fellow CESifo, 2003-

Education

University of Amsterdam, PhD Economics, 1992. Thesis: *Essays on human capital theory*.
University of Amsterdam, MSc Economics, 1985.

Fields of research

Economics of education; impact evaluation; development economics

Publications

In journals

- The anatomy of competitiveness. *Journal of the Economic Science Association*. (Forthcoming). (with Thomas Buser).
- Can competitiveness predict education and labor market outcomes? Evidence from incentivized choice and survey measures. *Review of Economics and Statistics* 108 (2026). 755–773. (with Thomas Buser and Muriel Niederle).
- Spillovers in fields of study: Siblings, cousins, and neighbors. *Journal of Public Economics* 238 (2024). 105193. (with Stanislav Avdeev, Nadine Ketel and Bas van der Klaauw).
- The effect of monthly cash transfers during 5 years on households' wealth. *Economic Development and Cultural Change* 72. (2024). 633–658. (with Andrea Molina-Vera).
- The performance of school assignment mechanisms in practice. *Journal of Political Economy* 131. (2023). 388–455. (with Monique de Haan, Pieter Gautier and Bas van der Klaauw).
- Heterogeneous effects of comprehensive vs. single-track academic schools: Evidence from admission lotteries. *Economics of Education Review*. (2023). 102363. (with Nienke Ruijs and Inge de Wolf).
- Household specialization and the child penalty in the Netherlands. *Labour Economics* 78. (2022). 102221. (with Elisabeth Artmann and Bas van der Klaauw).
- Do doctors increase the health care of their parents? Evidence from admission lotteries. *American Economic Journal: Applied Economics* 14. (2022). 164–184. (with Elisabeth Artmann and Bas van der Klaauw).

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- Field of study and partner choice. *Economics of Education Review* 84. (2021). 102149. (with Elisabeth Artmann, Nadine Ketel and Bas van der Klaauw).
 - Long-term effects of school-starting-age rules. *Economics of Education Review* 84. (2021). 102144. (with Simon ter Meulen and Bas van der Klaauw).
 - Preference heterogeneity and school segregation. *Journal of Public Economics* 197. (2021). 104400. (with Sandor Sovago and Bas van der Klaauw).
 - Do Dutch dentists extract a monopoly rent? *Journal of Health Economics* 63. (2019). 145–158. (with Nadine Ketel, Edwin Leuven and Bas van der Klaauw).
 - School choice in Amsterdam: Which schools are chosen when school choice is free? *Education Finance and Policy* 14. (2019) 1–30. (with Nienke Ruijs).
 - Peers at work: Evidence from the lab. *PLOS One* 13. (2018). (with Roel van Veldhuizen and Joep Sonnemans).
 - The impact of positive and negative income changes on the height and weight of young children. *World Bank Economic Review* 31. (2017). 786–808. (with Thomas Buser, Erik Plug, Juan Ponce and Jose Rosero).
 - Ability peer effects in university: Evidence from a randomized experiment. *Review of Economic Studies* 84. (2017). 547–578. (with Adam Booij and Edwin Leuven).
 - Tuition fees and sunk-cost effects. *Economic Journal* 126. (2016). 2342–2362. (with Nadine Ketel, Jona Linde and Bas van der Klaauw).
 - School consolidation and student achievement. *Journal of Law, Economics, & Organization* 32. (2016). 816–839. (with Monique de Haan and Edwin Leuven).
 - Parental responses to public investments in children: Evidence from a maximum class size rule. *Journal of Human Resources* 51. (2016). 832–868. (with Peter Fredriksson and Bjorn Ockert)
 - The returns to medical school: Evidence from admission lotteries. *American Economic Journal: Applied Economics* 8. (2016). 225–254. (with Nadine Ketel, Edwin Leuven and Bas van der Klaauw).
 - The impact of training vouchers on low-skilled workers. *Labour Economics* 31. (2014). 117–128. (with Diana Hidalgo and Dinand Webbink).
 - Gender, competitiveness and career choices. *Quarterly Journal of Economics* 129. (2014). 1409–1447. (with Thomas Buser and Muriel Niederle).
 - Gender peer effects in university: Evidence from a randomized experiment. *Economics of Education Review* 38. (2014). 51–63. (with Reyn Van Ewijk).
 - The effects of medical school on health outcomes: Evidence from admission lotteries. *Journal of Health Economics* 32. (2013). 698–707. (with Edwin Leuven and Inge de Wolf).
 - Can provision of free school uniforms harm attendance? Evidence from Ecuador. *Journal of Development Economics* 103. (2013). 43–51. (with Diana Hidalgo, Mercedes Onofa and Juan Ponce).
 - Ramadan, fasting and educational outcomes. *Economics of Education Review* 34. (2013). 219–226. (with Bas van der Klaauw).
 - Long-term effects of class size. *Quarterly Journal of Economics* 128. (2013). 249–285 (with Peter Fredriksson and Bjorn Ockert).
 - The impact of gender diversity on the performance of business teams: Evidence from a field experiment. *Management Science* 59. (2013). 1514–1528. (with Sander Hoogendoorn and Mirjam Van Praag).
 - The role of information in the take-up of student loans. *Economics of Education Review* 31. (2012). 33–44. (with Adam Booij and Edwin Leuven).

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- Rent-seeking versus productive activities in a multi-task experiment. *European Economic Review* 55. (2011). 630–643. (with Randolph Sloof and Joep Sonnemans).
 - Incentives versus sorting in tournaments: Evidence from a field experiment. *Journal of Labor Economics* 29. (2011). 637–658. (with Edwin Leuven, Joep Sonnemans and Bas van der Klaauw).
 - The impact of computer use on earnings in a developing country: Evidence from Ecuador. *Labour Economics* 18. (2011). 434–440. (with Juan Ponce).
 - Does studying abroad induce a brain drain? *Economica* 78. (2011). 347–366. (with Dinand Webbink).
 - The effect of financial rewards on students achievement: Evidence from a randomized experiment. *Journal of the European Economic Association* 8(6). (2010). 1243–1265. (with Edwin Leuven and Bas van der Klaauw).
 - Expanding schooling opportunities for 4-year-olds. *Economics of Education Review* 29. (2010). 319–328. (with Edwin Leuven, Mikael Lindahl and Dinand Webbink).
 - The impact of entrepreneurship education on entrepreneurship skills and motivation. *European Economic Review* 54. (2010). 442–454. (with Mirjam van Praag and Auke IJsselstein).
 - Financing lifelong learning. *Empirical Research in Vocational Education and Training* 1(1). (2009). 19–37. (with Harry Patrinos).
 - An empirical analysis of borrowing behaviour of higher education students in the Netherlands. *Economics of Education Review* 28. (2009). 170–177. (with Anja van den Broek).
 - An alternative approach to estimate the wage returns to private-sector training. *Journal of Applied Econometrics* 23. (2008). 423–434. (with Edwin Leuven).
 - Quasi-experimental estimates of the effect of class size on achievement in Norway. *Scandinavian Journal of Economics* 110(4). (2008). 663–693. (with Edwin Leuven and Marte Roenning).
 - The effect of extra funding for disadvantaged students on achievement. *Review of Economics and Statistics* 89(4). (2007). 721–736. (with Edwin Leuven, Mikael Lindahl and Dinand Webbink).
 - Wage effects of an extra year of basic vocational education. *Economics of Education Review* 26. (2007). 408–419. (with Dinand Webbink).
 - Does making specific investments unobservable boost investment incentives? *Journal of Economics and Management Strategy* 16. (2007). 911–942. (with Randolph Sloof and Joep Sonnemans).
 - Promotion rules and skill acquisition: an experimental study. *Economica* 74(2). (2007). 259–297. (with Randolph Sloof and Joep Sonnemans).
 - Who should invest in firm specific training? *Journal of Population Economics* 20(2). (2007). 329–357. (with Randolph Sloof and Joep Sonnemans).
 - On the importance of default breach remedies. *Journal of Institutional and Theoretical Economics* 163(1). (2007). 5–22. (with Randolph Sloof and Joep Sonnemans).
 - Breach remedies, reliance and renegotiation. *International Review of Law and Economics* 26(3). (2006). 263–296. (with Randolph Sloof, Arno Riedl and Joep Sonnemans).
 - Worker reciprocity and employer investment in training. *Economica* 72(285). (2005). 137–149. (with Edwin Leuven, Randolph Sloof and Chris van Klaveren).
 - Explaining international differences in male wage inequality by differences in demand and supply of skill. *Economic Journal* 114. (2004). 466–486. (with Edwin Leuven and Hans van Ophem).
 - Evaluating the effect of tax deductions on training. *Journal of Labor Economics* 22(1). (2004). 461–488. (with Edwin Leuven).
 - Cultural differences in ultimatum game experiments: Evidence from a meta-analysis. *Experimental Economics* 7. (2004). 171–188. (with Randolph Sloof and Gijs van de Kuilen).

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- Specific investments, holdup, and the outside option principle. *European Economic Review* 48. (2004). 1399–1410. (with Randolph Sloof and Joep Sonnemans).
 - An experimental comparison of reliance levels under alternative breach remedies. *The RAND Journal of Economics* 34(2). (2003). 205–222. (with Randolph Sloof, Edwin Leuven and Joep Sonnemans).
 - The need for marriage contracts: an experimental study. *Journal of Population Economics* 16. (2003). 431–453. (with Joep Sonnemans and Susan van Velzen).
 - The returns to education: microeconomics. *Journal of Economic Surveys* 17. (2003). 115–155. (with Colm Harmon and Ian Walker).
 - The causal effect of class size on scholastic achievement: Distinguishing the pure class size effect from the effect of changes in class composition. *Oxford Bulletin of Economics and Statistics* 64. (2002). 17–38. (with Simone Dobbelsteen and Jesse Levin).
 - Firm-specific human capital as a shared investment: Comment. *American Economic Review* 91(1). (2001). 342–347. (with Edwin Leuven).
 - Adverse selection and the demand for supplementary dental insurance. *De Economist* 149. (2001). 177–190. (with Martin Godfried and Frank van Tulder).
 - On the relation between asset ownership and specific investments. *Economic Journal* 111. (2001). 791–820. (with Joep Sonnemans and Randolph Sloof).
 - Schooling choices: preferences, discount rates, and rates of return. *Empirical Economics* 25. (2000). 15–34. (with Hans van Ophem).
 - A review of estimates of the schooling/earnings relationship, with tests for publication bias. *Labour Economics* 6. (1999). 453–470. (with Orley Ashenfelter and Colm Harmon).
 - Demand and supply of work-related training; evidence from four countries. *Research in Labor Economics* 18. (1999). 303–330. (with Edwin Leuven).
 - Health, wealth and happiness: why pursue a higher education? *Economics of Education Review* 17. (1998). 245–256. (with Joop Hartog).
 - Innovative ways to finance education and their relation to lifelong learning. *Education Economics* 6. (1998). 219–251.
 - An economic analysis of student financial aid schemes. *European Journal of Education* 33. (1998). 21–29.
 - Unravelling supply and demand factors in work-related training. *Oxford Economic Papers* 50. (1998). 266–283.
 - Is there a hidden technical potential? *De Economist* 145. (1997). 159–177. (with Dinand Webbink).
 - Returns to computer use: a simple test on the productivity interpretation. *Economics Letters* 55. (1997). 273–277.
 - A decomposition of training probabilities. *Applied Economics* 28. (1996). 799–805.
 - Firm-size wage differentials in the Netherlands. *Small Business Economics* 7. (1995). 173–182. (with Mirjam van Praag).
 - Enrolment in higher education in the Netherlands. *De Economist* 143. (1995). 367–380. (with Dinand Webbink).
 - Choosing the optimum mix of duration and effort in education. *Economics of Education Review* 14. (1995). 253–263.
 - Stochastic reservation and offer wages. *Labour Economics* 1. (1994). 383–390. (with Wim Groot).
 - Costs and revenues of investment in enterprise-related schooling. *Oxford Economic Papers* 58. (1994). 658–675. (with Joop Hartog and Wim Groot).

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- Earnings effects of different components of schooling: human capital versus screening. *Review of Economics and Statistics* 76. (1994). 317–321. (with Wim Groot).
 - Evidence on screening: a comment. *Economics of Education Review* 12. (1993). 89–90.
 - Public and private sector wages in the Netherlands. *European Economic Review* 37. (1993). 97–114. (with Joop Hartog).
 - Further evidence on the wage curve. *Economics Letters* 38. (1992). 355–359. (with Wim Groot and Eddie Mekkelholt).
 - Optimal investments in human capital under uncertainty. *Economics of Education Review* 11. (1992). 41–49. (with Wim Groot).
 - An empirical analysis of university choice and earnings. *De Economist* 140. (1992). 293–309. (with Wim Groot and Joop Hartog).
 - Study duration and earnings; a test in relation to the human capital screening debate. *Economics Letters* 40. (1992). 223–228.
 - Education and earnings in the Netherlands: An empirical analysis. *European Economic Review* 34. (1990). 1353–1375.
 - Education, allocation and earnings in the Netherlands: Overschooling? *Economics of Education Review* 7. (1988). 185–194. (with Joop Hartog).

In books

- Overeducation and mismatch in the labor market. In: Eric Hanushek, Stephen Machin and Ludger Woessmann, eds. *Handbook of the Economics of Education*. Volume 4. Elsevier (2011). (with Edwin Leuven).
- Underinvestment in training? In: Joop Hartog and Henriette Maassen van den Brink, eds. *Human Capital: Moving the Frontier*. Cambridge University Press (2007). (with Randolph Sloof and Joep Sonnemans).
- What should you know about the private returns to education? In: Joop Hartog and Henriette Maassen van den Brink, eds. *Human Capital: Moving the Frontier*. Cambridge University Press (2007). (with Joop Hartog).
- Using (quasi-)experiments to evaluate education interventions. In: Joop Hartog and Henriette Maassen van den Brink, eds. *Human Capital: Moving the Frontier*. Cambridge University Press (2007).
- The Effectiveness of Human Capital Policies for Disadvantaged Groups in the Netherlands. In: P. Peterson and L. Woessmann, eds. *Schools and the Equal Opportunity Problem*. MIT Press (2006). (with Edwin Leuven).
- Reasons and policies to stimulate lifelong learning. In: Fons van Wieringen and Graham Attwell, eds. *Vocational and Adult Education in Europe*. Kluwer (1999).
- Demand and supply of adult education and training. In: Paul Belanger and Albert Tuijnman, eds. *New Patterns of Adult Learning: A six-country comparative study*. Elsevier (1997). (with Willem Houtkoop).
- Returns to within company schooling of employees: The case of the Netherlands. In: Lisa M. Lynch, eds. *Training and the private sector: international comparisons*. Chicago University Press (1994). (with Joop Hartog and Wim Groot).
- Age, wage and education in the Netherlands. In: P. Johnson and K.F. Zimmerman, eds. *Labour markets in an aging Europe*. Cambridge University Press (1993). (with Joop Hartog and Coen Teulings).

Working papers

- School choice, school switching, and optimal assignment (with Tina Rozsos and Bas van der Klaauw).
- The (un)importance of school assignment (with Nadine Ketel, Sandor Sovago and Bas van der Klaauw). Revise and resubmit, *Economic Journal*.
- School segregation of teachers (with Rafiq Frierson and Bas van der Klaauw).
- Trade-offs between different early childhood interventions: Evidence from Ecuador (with Jose Rosero).
- The impact of cash transfers on school enrollment: Evidence from Ecuador (with Juan Ponce and Norbert Schady).
- The responsiveness of training participation to tax deductibility (with Edwin Leuven).

Teaching

Introductory and intermediate microeconomics; Labor economics; Introductory public economics; Undergraduate courses in methods of economic analysis and applied microeconometrics; Graduate courses in microeconomics and economics of education.

Thesis advisor

- Edwin Leuven, Studies in the economics of training, October 2001 (cum laude).
- Jesse Levin, Essays in the economics of education, October 2002 (joint with Joop Hartog).
- Ib Waterreus, Lessons in teacher pay, September 2003 (joint with Fons van Wieringen).
- Sandra Maximiano, Essays in organizational economics, February 2007 (co-advisor Randolph Sloof).
- Reyn van Ewijk, Empirical essays in education and health, October 2009 (co-advisor Peter Sleegers).
- Thomas Buser, Essays in behavioural economics, September 2012 (cum laude) (joint with Erik Plug).
- Jose Rosero Moncayo, On the importance of families and public policies for child development outcomes, September 2012.
- Nienke Ruijs, Empirical studies in the economics of education, February 2015 (joint with Henriette Maassen van den Brink).
- Nadine Ketel, Empirical studies in labor and education economics, January 2016 (joint with Bas van der Klaauw).
- Noemi Peter, Essays in empirical microeconomics, September 2016.
- Sabina Albrecht, Empirical studies in labour and migration economics, October 2018.
- Elisabeth Artmann, Educational choices and family outcomes, April 2021 (joint with Bas van der Klaauw).
- Yun Xiao, Fertility, parental investments and intergenerational mobility, September 2022 (joint with Pauline Rossi).
- Juanita Bloomfield Lescarbourea, Essays on early childhood interventions, January 2023 (joint with Ana Balsa).
- Simon ter Meulen, Grade retention, ability tracking and selection into education, June 2023 (joint with Bas van der Klaauw).
- Emilie Berkhout, Evaluations of education policies in Indonesia, June 2023 (joint with Menno Pradhan).
- Yang Zhong, Working under pressure, January 2026 (joint with Thomas Buser).
- Luisa de Azevedo, expected 2023 (joint with Bas van der Klaauw).

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- Rafiq Firperson, expected 2025 (joint with Bas van der Klaauw)
 - Stanislav Avdeev, expected 2026 (joint with Bas van der Klaauw)
 - Tina Rozsos, expected 2028 (joint with Bas van der Klaauw)
 - Alberto Antonello, expected 2029 (joint with Erik Plug)

Member thesis committee

Marc Vermeulen (1996), Bob Kuhry (1998), Gunnar Isacsson (1999), Athula Ranasinghe (2000), Louise Grogan (2001), Louise van de Venne, Bas Jacobs, Aslan Zorlu (2002), Adela Garcia Aracil (2003), Simona Raita (2005), Ernesto Reuben Paris, Gerrit Muller (2006), Miguel Portela, Justin van der Sluis, Laia Castany Teixidor (2007), Nicolai Kristensen (2008), Bouke Wartna (2009), Chris Bojke (2010), Arjan Non (2011), Thomas de Hoop, Jona Linde, Ron Diris (2012), Roel van Veldhuizen, Stephen Kastoryano (2013), Ilja Cornelisz, Roel van Elk, Sander Gerritsen (2014), Bernardo Lara Escalona (2015), Anna Adamecz, Marc van der Steeg (2016), Yuxin Yao (2017), Lennart Ziegler, Ferry Haan, Dany Kessel, Renata Rabovic, Matthijs Oosterveen (2018), Aisa Amagir (2020), Alexandra de Gendre, Martin Wiegand (2021), Melvin Vooren (2022), Katharina Brutt (2023), José Maria Cabrera Berobide, Julius Ilciukas, Lisa Timm (2025), Maddalena Totarelli, Sarah McNamara (2026).